

# Review of evidence on ‘what works’ and research directions on education in developing countries

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The purpose of this note is to generate insight into key trends in education programming and to help inform WUSC’s new education strategy. It reviews the latest evidence on ‘what works’ and best practices in education in developing countries. It zooms in on four key areas that are of particular interest for WUSC: (i) fragile contexts; (ii) girls’ education, gender equality and social norms; (iii) continuous professional development for teachers; and (iv) localisation. It then describes current directions for research in education in developing countries.

## 1. Syntheses of evidence on ‘what works’ and best practices in education

Since 2010 there have been many reviews and meta-analyses of what works for education in developing countries. Many of these have been compiled and compared by David Evans and colleagues at the Center for Global Development (Evans, 2023; Evans & Popova, 2016). The Annex in this document provides a list of all of the recent systematic reviews, meta-analyses, and similar reviews of the effectiveness literature.

For the following brief review, I take *Cost-effective approaches to improve global learning* (GEEAP, 2023) as a starting point, and then reviewed other studies for points of agreement, difference, or nuance. The GEEAP report has the advantage that it is the most recent - and able to cover a large number of studies that have been carried out since earlier systematic reviews were conducted; it includes consideration of cost (while earlier studies often had too little data); it uses the learning-adjusted years of schooling (LAYS) methodology where possible; and it draws on many of the earlier reviews. The following interventions have been covered in GEEAP and other recent reviews:

- Reviews agree that supporting teachers with **structured pedagogy** is both highly cost-effective and supported by a strong body of evidence (GEEAP, 2023; Snilstveit et al., 2015). These typically involve a package with structured lesson plans, learning materials, and ongoing teacher support. (Snilstveit et al., 2015) also find that structured pedagogy programmes had the largest and most consistent effects over time, and note that the programmes address multiple constraints at once. By contrast, general teacher training at scale is often not evaluated, and is considered to be delivered in ways that are not effective (GEEAP, 2023; Popova et al., 2022).
- GEEAP find that **information on the benefits, costs, and quality of education** is another ‘best buy’. Earlier reviews are less clear; Snilstveit et al judged that there is

insufficient evidence on these programmes. The difference partly reflects new studies that have been added to the more recent review, and also reflects the very low cost of these programmes, which means that they are highly cost-effective even if effect size is modest.

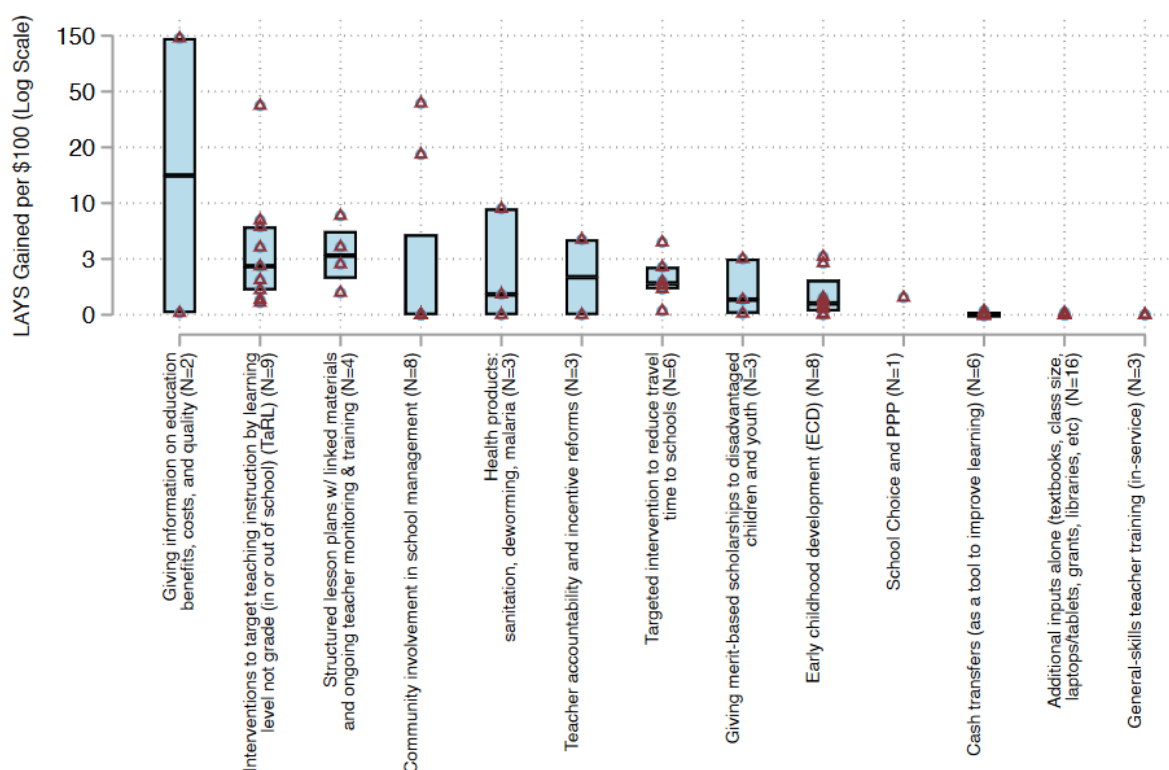
- **Targeting teaching instruction by learning level**, not grade (in or out of school) is the third of GEEAP's 'best buys', a category that includes 'Teaching at the Right Level'. Snilstveit et al. only consider two studies of tracking students by ability, finding 'relatively small' improvements in learning, and noting the potential for inequalities to be reinforced; they find that remedial education can be relatively effective, although with varied outcomes across programmes.
- **Mother tongue instruction**: This is not considered in GEEAP, but several recent studies have found mother tongue instruction programmes effective in improving learning outcomes in sub-Saharan Africa, with impacts both on mother tongue literacy and second language literacy (Evans & Mendez Acosta, 2021).
- **Early childhood development**: Parent-directed early stimulation (age 0-3) and quality pre-primary education (age 3-5) are considered 'good buys' by GEEAP.
- **Overcoming access barriers**: GEEAP lists reducing travel times to schools as a 'good buy'.
- **Cash transfers and scholarships**: GEEAP finds that merit-based scholarships are cost-effective 'good buys', while Snilstveit et al. found them 'promising'. Snilstveit et al. find cash transfers had consistent and substantive positive effects on school participation, but do not appear to improve learning outcomes. GEEAP considers that cash transfers are effective but relatively expensive, suitable only for school systems with larger budgets. (However, it could be argued that cash transfers can be considered as partly a form of social protection, and do not necessarily come out of education budgets.)
- **Education materials and technology**: GEEAP finds software for personalised learning and mobile phone interventions to be 'promising but with limited evidence'. More broadly they warn that investing in inputs such as laptops, tablets, textbooks, additional teachers, school buildings *alone* are bad buys when other issues are not addressed. Snilstveit et al. agree that providing education-related 'hardware' (materials and technology) may be necessary but not sufficient, but importantly, note that the failure of these programmes often reflects implementation challenges which meant that the inputs was not even delivered as intended. They find that computer-assisted learning has had 'decidedly mixed' effects, including negative effects on learning in some cases.
- **School health and school feeding**: Snilstveit et al. argue that school feeding is 'promising' for both access and learning; but more recent studies have found clearer effects on access and learning (Evans & Mendez Acosta, 2021). GEEAP agree that school feeding is effective, but like cash transfers, argue that it is too expensive for many systems. Again, though, it could be argued that school feeding is partly a health and social protection benefit, and can and should be funded separately from the mainstream education budget. GEEAP considers deworming to be a good buy while safeguarding students from violence is 'promising but with limited evidence'. Snilstveit et al. find that school health programmes are mostly beneficial, but with small average effects and large variation between contexts.
- **Teacher incentives and hiring**: These programmes have had small and varied effects, according to Snilstveit et al. But reviewing more recent studies in

sub-Saharan Africa, (Evans & Mendez Acosta, 2021) reveal nuanced and often positive effects of these programmes. For example, teacher performance bonuses were partially effective by themselves in Tanzania, but more effective when coupled with school grants, suggesting that multiple constraints may need to be addressed at once to get the most out of this type of intervention.

- **Community-based monitoring** increases enrolment and learning in some contexts, while school-based management does not improve school participation on average and has small or no effects on learning (Snilstveit et al.). In both cases there is considerable heterogeneity.
- **Public-private partnerships** can increase enrollment in some contexts, with small average increases in learning outcomes (Snilstveit et al.)

The analysis of cost-effectiveness in terms of learning-adjusted years of schooling by (Angrist et al., 2020) illustrates the range of results for the programmes considered in these reviews. Many cost-effective programmes can deliver around 3 LAYS per US\$100, but many programmes, even within the same ‘best buy’ categories, deliver close to 0 LAYS per US\$100. Their analysis also reveals how there are very few studies with appropriate effectiveness and cost data in most of the categories. For example, the estimate for information interventions is based on only two studies, one of which is an outlier with very high effectiveness while the other is close to zero. (The GEEAP review does refer to nine studies, but not all of these have both cost and effectiveness data.)

Figure 1: Cost-effectiveness of studies in (Angrist et al., 2020)



Taken from (Angrist et al., 2020)

It is useful to note the limitations of some of these reviews:

- They strongly emphasise ‘gold standard’ randomised controlled trial (RCTs) methods and other experimental designs. They make little use of descriptive research or qualitative studies. The idea that RCTs are more rigorous ways of establishing causation than other methods has been questioned; arguably, they only generate useful knowledge as part of a cumulative programme of social science research that uses multiple methods (Cartwright, 2021; Deaton & Cartwright, 2018).
- Studies based on descriptive data are sometimes better placed to establish the success of policies adopted at scale. For example, removal of user fees for primary education was adopted in many countries in the 1990s. Was this policy change successful in increasing enrolment? There are few experimental studies that address this question (Snilstveit et al., 2015), but large increases in enrollment and attainment coincided with the roll-out of the policy (Crawford, 2024; Moussa & Omoeva, 2020). We cannot conclusively identify how much of the enrollment increase can be causally attributed to the removal of fees, but the descriptive evidence is nevertheless persuasive that fee removal - within the context of wider policy reforms to universalise primary education - had an important effect. Experimental studies are not necessarily the best approach to understand the effects and costs of this policy.
- They have relatively little to say on mechanisms, implementation and scale-up, partly because of their reliance on quantitative experimental studies.
- With a few exceptions, it has not usually been possible to conduct experimental studies in conflict- or crisis-affected contexts.
- It may be more informative to examine successful programmes in detail to understand what made them work, rather than computing average effects for a category of intervention, when each category hides considerable variation in context, design, duration, and cost.
- Experimental studies often require measurable change to happen within a very limited time-frame, creating a potential bias in favour of quick wins over slower but perhaps more sustainable improvement. However, this can also be considered a limitation of much aid-funded education programming and its tendency to operate on short time scales.

The GEEAP adds an overall recommendation that specific interventions should be part of a system-wide reform, which also requires political commitment. Specifically, they need to move away from a focus on elite students, and towards meeting the needs of the entire student population, including through reforms of curricula, textbooks, and exam systems. Some cost-effective interventions circumvent this need for systemic reform for example by operating separate catch-up classes, but in the longer term, changes to the whole system are more likely to be sustainable and reach all learners.

## 2. Zooming in: best practices in 5 key areas

### 2.1. Fragile contexts

Many of the world’s children live in fragile contexts, and many of the recent studies on education have taken place in countries affected by conflict or fragility, as measured (for

example) by the World Bank's [classification](#). However, studies have tended not to give much consideration to how the fragility in these countries affects best practices for education or the effectiveness of interventions. (In some cases this may be because fragility or conflict is localised, and studies are conducted in more stable or peaceful parts of the country.) None of the major systematic reviews consider conflict or fragility as a factor in effectiveness, or attempt to disaggregate fragile and non-fragile contexts (although the GEEAP report mentions some mention of conflict).

A 2015 review found relatively few rigorous studies on education in crisis-affected countries, and very few that took the disaster or conflict into account, but a large number of observational studies (Burde et al., 2015). This review found strong evidence for community-based education, especially for girls at primary level, and for community-based monitoring; and promising results for providing female teachers, girls-only schools, accelerated learning programmes, tailored training for teachers, mobile phone technology, and distance learning. Little evidence was available on approaches for including newly displaced or refugee children, such as double shifts at existing schools, or opening schools within camps.

Among the more recent studies that explicitly consider fragility, a school-based socioemotional learning program, the International Rescue Committee's Learning to Read in a Healing Classroom (LRHC), was found to have positive effects on school and classroom quality, and child academic and socioemotional outcomes, in three conflict-affected provinces of the Democratic Republic of the Congo (Aber et al., 2017). A study of school feeding in conflict-affected areas of Mali showed that it increased both attendance and attainment in school, with larger effects on attainment for girls than boys; by contrast, general food distribution could have negative effects on school attendance (Aurino et al., 2019). However the effects on attainment were mostly found among children who were not in the immediate vicinity of the conflict, suggesting there are limits to the effects of such interventions.

During COVID-19 school closures, remote tuition by mobile phone has been found effective in improving learning, across India, Kenya, Nepal, the Philippines and Uganda (Angrist et al., 2023). This intervention was highly cost-effective, and similarly effective whether delivered by NGO or government teachers, making it an interesting option for improving resilience to emergencies at scale in fragile contexts.

The World Bank's white paper on education in fragile and conflict-affected situations (Holland et al., 2022) identifies the serious challenges in ensuring all children are learning and safe in these situations, and the need for more funding for education in emergencies. However it does not set out much guidance on the types of approach needed in these settings. The authors' interviews with a range of organisations engaged in education in fragile and conflict-affected settings revealed "broad agreement that it is urgent to meet the educational needs of children and youth affected by FCV, but little consensus on how the needs can be met". Options for them ranged from "standalone/parallel systems by private actors, to technology solutions, to delivering services through national systems". Developing the capacity of national governments, to ensure the long-term sustainability of interventions, has not been a priority for these organisations, according to the World Bank team of authors.

## Education for refugees

For refugees, UNHCR and others advocate for their inclusion into national education systems as the only long-term solution, especially given the protracted nature of most refugees' displacement (UNESCO & UNHCR, 2023). Including children as early and fully as possible in national systems and in mainstream classes provides them with the best chance to learn, while keeping them in separate parallel systems is more likely to result in them dropping out or not attending at all (Crul et al., 2019; Marcus et al., 2023). The existence of a refugee camp with associated school provision that local children can also attend, was found to improve learning for both refugee and host country children in Rwanda (Bilgili et al., 2019).

Inclusion hinges on laws and policies that shape how refugees obtain recognition and documentation, access education, navigate transitions, and certify their learning. Specific reforms and interventions can include ensuring schools and examination centres are available near refugee settlements, waving examination fees, adapting test-taking conditions, creating pathways to qualification for refugee teachers, catch-up programmes, allowing flexibility in curricula, and creating certificates that can work across borders.

There appears to be widespread agreement on the principles of inclusion behind these policy suggestions, but relatively little evidence on how best to implement them (Marcus et al., 2023). There is a substantial body of research on refugee education, but few robust impact evaluations. One review found over 1800 articles on refugee education, but only 5 used quantitative experimental or quasi-experimental methods, and an additional 3 used less rigorous quantitative methods (e.g. before-after with no control group, or control and treatment groups were not randomly selected) (Palik & Østby, 2023). Of these 8 selected studies, only 3 are in low- or middle-income countries:

- Child and youth learning centres (CYLCs) in Ethiopia's Buramino Camp for those fleeing conflict in Somalia, which were found to increase literacy and numeracy skills among both youth and younger children (Metzler et al., 2021).
- Online, game-based education for Syrian refugees in Turkey (Sirin et al., 2018). Students in the intervention group had significantly higher language scores than children in the control group.
- A cash transfer for Syrian children in Lebanon, designed to cover costs of commuting to school (de HOOP et al., 2019). The intervention was associated with increased education expenditure and better attendance.

There are ethical, logistical, and financial obstacles to conducting evaluations in some refugee contexts, but the lack of rigorous evidence on what works remains a problem (Habib, 2019; Palik & Østby, 2023).

**Accelerated education programmes** are considered useful for refugees because of data suggesting that children lose an average of three to four years of education through forced displacement (Marcus et al., 2023; World Bank & UNHCR, 2021). A meta-analysis of accelerated education programmes by the Norwegian Refugee Council found that they had made a clear contribution to providing access for populations who would otherwise not have been able to access education at all (Shah, 2015). The programmes also provided pathways for beneficiaries to enter formal schooling, but varied in the numbers of children who

succeeded in making this transition, and barriers such as costs still prevented some from continuing their education.

As noted above, **cash transfers** have been found to be effective in improving school attendance. In several countries, such as Colombia, Chile, Türkiye and Brazil, refugees are able to access national cash transfer and sometimes other social protection programmes, so that specific programmes targeting refugees may not be needed; evidence from Ecuador suggests that social protection programmes open to both refugees and the local population can help build social cohesion (Marcus et al., 2023).

**EdTech programmes** can serve as an important stopgap measure in emergency and displacement settings, when access to formal education is limited, according to a 2018 review (Tauson & Stannard, 2018). The review found that they are considered most effective when they match the expectations of parents and students, align with curricula, and are adaptable to the context and individual needs of learners.

There are several reviews of **psychosocial and mental health** support for refugee children, often delivered via schools (Frounfelker et al., 2020; Simenec & Reid, 2022; Sullivan & Simonson, 2016; Tyrer & Fazel, 2014). Most of these are in high-income countries, although several studies have been conducted in Uganda and Sierra Leone (Tyrer & Fazel, 2014), showing some success in programmes to treat post-traumatic stress disorder and depression, for example, among refugee and internally displaced adolescents.

## 2.2. Girls' education, gender equality and social norms

Targeted interventions to support girls' learning have proven effective (GEEAP, 2023). Interventions have particularly targeted adolescent girls, as this is the age group at which disparities in favour of boys are largest. Interventions that do *not* target a gender such as reducing the cost of school often benefit whichever gender is falling behind in that context (Evans & Yuan, 2022), but there remain barriers that specifically affect girls (Rose & Yorke, 2019). Effective interventions to increase girls' enrollment have included: "programs teaching girls to negotiate with their parents, enrollment drives that spread awareness about benefits of girls' education, female-only toilets, take-home rations on attending school, and constructing girl-friendly schools" (GEEAP, 2023).

School fee elimination, school meals, making schools more physically accessible, and improving the quality of pedagogy are among the interventions shown to improve learning outcomes for girls at scale (Evans et al., 2024). Interventions such as sanitation and safe spaces have also shown promising results on participation, though with less clear impact on learning per se.

Many development actors now look beyond gender parity in access and learning outcomes, to the idea of a gender-transformative education system that explicitly seeks to redress gender inequalities and empower disadvantaged populations (Bullard, 2023). Female teachers and school leaders, prevention of gender-based violence, and gender-responsive teaching and school cultures are among the policy areas considered effective in advancing this type of goal.

## 2.3. Continuous professional development for teachers

Interventions that provide support and clear guidance to teachers, including through lesson plans, learning materials, skills-based teacher training, and teacher mentoring, are considered ‘best buys’ by GEEAP (GEEAP, 2023). The interaction between different components of teacher support - for example, not providing teacher training alone but offering continuous mentoring to help teachers put it into practice - is thought to be essential to program impact. Notwithstanding the success of these projects, GEEAP also argue that typical standalone in-service training is often *not* effective, because it rarely incorporates elements such as practical training and classroom practice.

What types of programme are effective? Those that link participation to career incentives, have a specific subject focus, incorporate lesson enactment in the training, and include initial face-to-face training tend to show higher student learning gains (Popova et al., 2022). Implementers themselves believe follow-up visits to be among the most important elements for effectiveness. General and theoretical guidance to teachers tends to have little effect, while support targeted towards specific subjects (e.g. early grade literacy or numeracy) or topics (e.g. classroom management) can raise learning outcomes (Bullard, 2020). Support embedded in the school setting and sustained through mentoring is more effective than one-off workshops in centralised locations (Bullard, 2020; Popova et al., 2022).

Some programs that have provided detailed scripts and lesson plans have been shown to be effective, but in most cases, effective interventions have not involved fully scripted lessons (GEEAP, 2023). The GEEAP consider that less structured teacher support can be used in contexts where teachers have relatively high content knowledge and pedagogical skills.

“Teaching at the right level” - an approach in which groups of children are tested and then taught with materials matched to their current level of knowledge (Banerjee et al., 2017) - is also highlighted by the GEEAP as a cost-effective intervention. TaRL has been tested both with existing teachers and community volunteers, and involves giving specific training to existing teachers, and also providing on-going academic and practical support to them. There are also forms of targeted teaching that involve putting students into separate tracks by ability, and these have been effective in some countries. However, in OECD countries, tracking has also been associated with worsening equity (OECD, 2012).

It can be questioned whether TaRL as an added-on intervention could ultimately be replaced with a more integral set of changes at the system level. For example, training and practices that incorporate better formative assessment, less strict adherence to covering all content in a curriculum (especially where curricula may be ambitious and over-packed), and support teachers to adapt both their style and content of teaching to the needs of their students, might remove the need for separate TaRL classes.

One area that has received surprisingly little attention in relation to teacher training is language of instruction. Some 40% of children are thought not to have access to education in a language they speak or understand, with negative effects on learning (UNESCO, 2016); children also learn a second language better once they have already learned literacy in their



mother tongue (Mohohlwane et al., 2023). Meanwhile, across seven African countries, only 7% of fourth-grade teachers had the minimum knowledge necessary to teach language (Bold et al., 2017), in part because they are expected to teach a language that is not their own mother tongue. Shifting language policy is one system-wide change that might alleviate some of the problems around teachers' capacity, although mother tongue instruction also has its own challenges.

## 2.4. Localisation

Locally-led development can be defined as “the process in which local actors – encompassing individuals, communities, networks, organizations, private entities, and governments – set their own agendas, develop solutions, and bring the capacity, leadership, and resources to make those solutions a reality.” (USAID, 2021). It can fall on a spectrum from local actors having some say in an externally driven programme, to local actors being fully in control, and requesting financial and/or technical support from external agencies for an initiative that originates with, and is managed by, them. For donors, localisation often refers to engagement of host country governments, but in principle, it can also refer to sub-national levels and to beneficiary populations themselves having greater say or control over initiatives that benefit them.<sup>1</sup>

Localisation of education programmes in development assistance can include at least the following elements:

- Improving government ownership and engagement, including through working with government systems
- Giving aid directly to either governments or non-government organisations in recipient countries, with some autonomy over how they use the money
- Engaging lower levels of government and other actors at subnational level (district, school, community) to manage programmes
- Adapting and scaling up education interventions to local contexts - for example interventions trialled in one country to another country, or scaling up a pilot to cover the whole of a country.

Each of these elements is often recognised as an important, yet progress towards localising aid to education has been tentative, and the evidence base remains limited. Some considerations and evidence are presented in the following sub-sections.

### 2.4.1. Engaging governments and working within government systems

A central insight on aid effectiveness is that external aid investments are more likely to catalyse sustained development processes when they reinforce a country's internally determined development priorities and arrangements (USAID, 2014). Alignment with government priorities is considered particularly important in fragile and conflict-affected situations, but can take different forms depending on state capacity and commitment (DFID, 2010).

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<sup>1</sup> See also the Overseas Development Institute [series of research reports](#) on localising aid in 2013-2014.

Many aid programmes appear to be more effective when delivered by NGOs rather than through government systems and workers (Bold et al., 2018; Vivalt, 2020), although some interventions have shown similar effectiveness whether delivered by NGO or government workers (Angrist et al., 2023). The [Teaching at the Right Level](#) initiative, in particular, has been rolled out in a number of countries with attention to engaging governments politically and in delivery (Banerjee et al., 2017). Banerjee et al note, for example, that in one version of this intervention, volunteer teachers ended up being absorbed into schools as regular teachers, and no longer applied the TARL approach, with no impact on test scores; in another, teachers were allocated an hour each day to use the TARL approach, with better results. As approaches are scaled up and incorporated into existing school systems, local actors change implementation in ways that respond to their local imperatives, and these changes may not even be visible to researchers who only examine impact. Both political reaction and contextual factors may affect the implementation of an intervention.

#### 2.4.2. Direct aid

During 2019-2021, only 2% of education aid was transferred directly to NGOs, CSOs, private or other local organisations in low- or middle-income countries, while 45% was transferred by donors to their own governments, to their own universities, or to other organisations based in donor countries (Hares et al., 2023). Multilaterals give a much larger share of aid directly to recipient governments. USAID is one donor that has signalled a high level of commitment to localisation, through advocacy and research publications since at least 2012, and it has increased the share of its funding going to local partners from around 4% in 2012 to over 10% in 2022 (Irakunda, 2022).

#### 2.4.3. Engaging sub-national and non-governmental actors

In practice, localisation has often been about working with national governments and systems, but it is also recognised that other levels (provincial, district, community, school) are important; systems exist and vary at these levels, and actors at lower levels often have the best knowledge on what interventions will work or not. For example, in Uganda, community-based monitoring of school performance using scorecards was more effective when community members defined the issues that appeared on the scorecards than when education officials and development partners defined them (USAID, 2014). Strengthening local capacity is an important part of working with local systems (USAID, 2022).

Enabling civil society is also recognised as a core principle for development cooperation, through “1) respecting, protecting and promoting civic space; 2) supporting and engaging with civil society; and 3) incentivising CSO effectiveness, transparency and accountability” (OECD, 2024). Funding *through* CSOs, as implementing partners, remains [much more common](#) than funding *to* CSOs.

#### 2.4.4. Adapting education interventions to local contexts

There is a growing acceptance that aid efforts should be demand-driven or country-driven, but aid agencies often struggle to translate this into practice. They continue to rely on somewhat rigid processes, and lack the ability to innovate in their operations (Bernard, 2024). A related finding in the impact evaluation literature is that there is great heterogeneity in the evaluated impact of similar programmes in different settings, so that it is difficult to

generalise impact evaluation results, at least without knowing background information on the implementation and context (Vivalt, 2020).

‘Inclusive coordination’ is needed in scaling up, and can happen in ways that are directed from the top down, or that evolve more organically through different actors working together at more local levels. Evaluation methods in such contexts may need to become more dynamic - recognising that cause-and-effect relationships may not be stable as the context and scale of an intervention change (Gargani & McLean, 2017).

[Problem-driven iterative adaptation](#) is an approach to overcoming “capability traps” that often hold governments back in implementing reforms or interventions (Andrews et al., 2017). It involves breaking down problems into their root causes, identifying entry points, searching for solutions, taking action, reflecting, adapting, and acting again. While in many ways the approach may sound obvious, it remains opposed to the top-down planning and somewhat rigid planning models that continue to be used in international development work, and particularly highlights the difficulty that implementers have in putting in place a monitoring system and adapting a programme rapidly in response to learning, with some practical suggestions on how to do this better. The *Real Time Scaling Labs* approach developed at the Brookings Institution (Perlman Robinson et al., 2021) attempts to apply similar ideas of participation, adaptation and learning to scaling up education programmes, and the new What Works Hub for Global Education picks up on some of these concerns in its focus on [‘implementation science’](#).

There remain few clearly documented cases of how this approach works in practice. However one study documents how a focus on continually adapting the model and a culture of data-driven decision-making - including ‘A/B testing’ traditionally used by the technology sector - by the implementer reportedly helped drive the success of TaRL in Botswana (Wyss et al., 2023).

### 3. Direction of new research initiatives on education in developing countries

Some major recent research initiative on education in developing countries include:

- The [Research on Improving Systems of Education \(RISE\) Programme](#) - with teams in Ethiopia, India, Indonesia, Nigeria, Pakistan, Tanzania and Vietnam. Funded by the UK’s FCDO, RISE ran from 2013 to 2023, generating large amounts of research including around the political economy of how education systems can align around the goal of improved learning outcomes.
- The Global Education Evidence Advisory Panel (GEEAP), formed in July 2020, continues to provide evidence-based guidance on education for low- and middle-income countries.
- The [What Works Hub for Global Education](#) aims to generate evidence on how to take effective responses to scale, developing a new ‘science of implementation’ in education. Funded by FCDO, the Bill & Melinda Gates Foundation, and others, it will initially be focused on India, Pakistan, Rwanda and Tanzania, with additional projects

in Bangladesh, Botswana, Ghana, Kenya, Malawi, Nigeria, Sierra Leone, and South Africa.

- UNICEF's Global Office of Research and Foresight (GORAF, also known as Innocenti) focuses on three areas in education: what works at school level; what works at policy level; and how to scale up solutions. Recent projects include positive deviance research on the practices and behaviours that make some schools perform better than others; technology for personalised learning; and teacher attendance and time on task in Africa.
- The UNESCO Global Education Monitoring report has a theme each year, on which it consolidates existing and new research. The 2023 report focused on [technology in education](#), while the 2024 report will focus on [leadership](#). The Report is also introducing a new series to advance dialogue on the interrelationship of education with the other Sustainable Development Goals. The first, due out shortly, is on [education and climate change](#).
- A recent CGD paper sets out [directions for research on girls' education](#)
- [Research on Scaling the Impact of Innovations on Education \(ROSIE\)](#), run by the Brookings Institution with GPE-KIX funding, studies the process of scaling interventions. It was extended for a second phase in 2024.

FCDO remains a major funder of research on education in developing countries. As well as the What Works Hub, currently active projects funded by FCDO with research components relating to education include:

- [SIEF Strategic Impact Evaluation Fund](#): Active since 2011/12 and due to wrap up in 2021/22 (but currently still marked as active), this World Bank executed trust fund planned to deliver over 50 high quality impact evaluations, many of them in education.
- [New research commissioning centre](#): Started in 2022, the establishment with 3ie of a new research commissioning centre aims to accelerate the delivery of research, including through strategic partnership with the UK academic sector.
- [Education Research in Conflict and Protracted Crisis \(ERICC\)](#): Started in 2022 and due to run to 2026, this program focuses on Syria, Lebanon, Jordan, Bangladesh, Myanmar, Nigeria and South Sudan, and aims to provide rigorous research on what works to deliver education in these contexts. ([Publications](#))
- [THRIVE early childhood development research programme](#) in Ghana, Bangladesh, Kiribati, Sierra Leone and Tanzania. ([Site](#))
- [Scaling Access and Learning in Education](#): will provide up to £68m over five years (2023-2028) to increase the uptake of cost-effective interventions that deliver foundational learning outcomes for all, especially disadvantaged girls, including through up to 10 "test-learn-adapt" pilots. (It is not yet clear which countries will be included).
- [Disability Inclusive Development Programme](#): Due to run from 2017 to 2026, the programme will test innovative approaches to disability inclusion, including in education, and generate research to fill knowledge gaps.
- [EdTech Hub](#): Due to run from 2017 to 2027, this global research partnership aims to bridge evidence gaps around the use of technology, working directly in Bangladesh, Ghana, Kenya, Malawi, Pakistan, Sierra Leone and Tanzania. ([Site](#))

- [Young Lives at Work](#): Continuing the long-running Young Lives programme, this phase, due to run from 2019 to 2026, focuses on educational trajectories and access to higher education and labour market entry, in Peru, Ethiopia, India and Vietnam.

## Annex: list of recent reviews

### Broad reviews and meta-analysis

1. [School Resources and Educational Outcomes in Developing Countries: A Review of the Literature from 1990-2010](#) (Glewwe et al., 2013)
2. [Improving School Education Outcomes in Developing Countries: Evidence, Knowledge Gaps, and Policy Implications](#) (Glewwe & Muralidharan, 2015)
3. [The Challenge of Education and Learning in the Developing World](#) (Kremer et al., 2013)
4. [Quality Education for All Children? What Works in Education in Developing Countries](#) (Krishnarathne et al., 2013)
5. [What Works to Improve the Quality of Student Learning in Developing Countries?](#) (Masino & Niño-Zarazúa, 2015)
6. [Improving Learning in Primary Schools of Developing Countries: A Meta-Analysis of Randomized Experiments](#) (McEwan, 2013)
7. [Field Experiments in Education in Developing Countries](#) (Muralidharan, 2017)
8. [Improving Educational Outcomes in Developing Countries: Lessons from Rigorous Evaluations](#) (Ganimian & Murnane, 2016)
9. [Interventions for Improving Learning Outcomes and Access to Education in Low- and Middle-Income Countries: A Systematic Review](#), (Snijlsteit et al., 2015, 2016) [Summary]

### More specific reviews

10. [EdTech in Developing Countries: A Review of the Evidence](#) (Rodriguez-Segura, 2022)
11. On South Asia: [Improving education outcomes in South Asia](#) (Asim et al., 2015) and [Improving Learning Outcomes in South Asia](#) (Asim et al., 2016)
12. On Africa: [Identifying Effective Education Interventions in Sub-Saharan Africa](#) (Conn, 2017); [Education in Africa: What Are We Learning?](#) (Evans & Mendez Acosta, 2021); and [Facing Forward: Schooling for Learning in Africa](#) (Bashir et al., 2018)
13. On girls' education: [What We Learn about Girls' Education from Interventions That Do Not Focus on Girls](#) (Evans & Yuan, 2022); [Policies and interventions to remove gender-related barriers to girls' school participation and learning in low- and middle-income countries](#) (Psaki et al., 2022); [Girls' Education at Scale](#) (Evans et al., 2024)
14. [How to recruit teachers for hard-to-staff schools: A systematic review of evidence from low- and middle-income countries](#) (Evans & Mendez Acosta, 2023)

## Analytical reviews

1. [Cost-effective Approaches to Improve Global Learning](#) (GEEAP, 2023)
2. [Schooling for All: Feasible Strategies to Achieve Universal Education](#) (Sandefur, 2022)
3. [How to Improve Education Outcomes Most Efficiently? A Comparison of 150 Interventions Using the New Learning-Adjusted Years of Schooling Metric](#) (Angrist et al., 2020)
4. World Bank's [World Development Report 2018](#) (World Bank, 2018)

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